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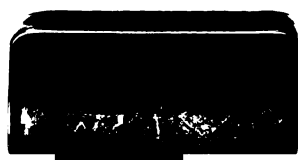
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REPUBLIC OF VIETNAM



INAUGURAL ADDRESS

By

PRESIDENT NGUYEN VAN THIEU

October 31, 1967

*This is the text of the Inaugural Address
delivered by President Nguyen Van Thieu
on October 31, 1967*

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PRESIDENT NGUYEN VAN THIEU

INAUGURAL ADDRESS

by

PRESIDENT NGUYEN VAN THIEU

October 31, 1967

My fellow countrymen:

Three months ago, in order to continue to serve the ideals of freedom and democracy, and restore peace and prosperity to all of you, we stood for election, with a program consisting of three main objectives: To set up democratic institutions, to find a solution to the war and to improve social conditions.

On September 3rd, you placed your confidence in us through a free, democratic, fair, and honest election and gave us the great and heavy responsibility of leading the country at this extremely critical time.

Today in taking office, amidst this sacred atmosphere, in communion with our ancestors, and our heroes, before the entire nation I solemnly pledge:

- To safeguard the fatherland,
- To respect the constitution,
- To serve the interests of the nation and the people, and
- To do my utmost to fulfill the responsibilities of President of the Republic of Vietnam.

These pledges I consider as tenets which will strictly guide all of my thoughts and actions, and those of the entire executive machinery which you have entrusted to me.

Today, we are entering the fifth year since the 1963 revolution. During this time, the country has experienced many difficulties and changes, which have consumed a great deal of energy. Nevertheless, these four long years full of challenges in fighting and building, have been useful to us in choosing a path which we definitely must follow in order to move forward, and begin a new phase filled with greatness and promise. By greatness and promise, I mean the glories and the difficulties which await us. I think that today is not only the first day of an

ordinary executive term. Nor does it mark the victory by an individual or a group of individuals seeking to consolidate their political ambitions. To achieve this day, our armed forces and people have made many sacrifices, and our allies have contributed a great deal of efforts.

Thus, today must be a day commemorating the ideology of freedom. Today marks the fruits of the efforts towards democracy. It also symbolizes the solid alliance among allied countries working for common security and progress for the entire world.

My fellow countrymen:

Amidst these great and hallowed ideas to which I have just referred and on the basis of the mandate which you have given to me, may I voice the firm resolve of our entire nation to realize a national policy which includes the three following guidelines:

- Democracy building,
- Peace restoration,
- Social improvement.

With such a policy, we are determined to defeat these three enemies:

- Totalitarianism,
- War,
- Injustice and backwardness,

in order to make our country

- Democratic,
- Peaceful,
- and Progressive.

In the present heroic struggle for self-defense, our Republic of Vietnam has always shown itself to be a freedom and peace loving nation. Our policy is to be ready to have friendly relations on the basis of equality with every country which respects Vietnam's sovereignty and territorial integrity.

We are grateful to all nations which give us material and moral support in our difficult struggle for self-defense and in our efforts to rebuild the country.

Our policy toward our neighboring countries is to have a good relationship, to respect their sovereignty and territorial integrity and to solve every problem through understanding, reciprocal assistance and mutual respect.

We are ready to cooperate with all friendly nations so that the peace and security of every nation can be guaranteed. On the other hand, we are ready to contribute, according to our capabilities, to the well-being and prosperity of the world.

After more than twenty years of sufferings, mournings and destruction caused by war, our people—more than anyone else—long for an early restoration of peace.

To realize this legitimate aspiration, our government has always sincerely welcomed and responded favorably to all peace proposals regardless of their source. Moreover, we ourselves have put forth many proposals aimed at solving the Vietnamese problem in a peaceful manner.

Today, entrusted by the entire people with the important responsibility of leading the nation, I once again confirm that I will make a direct proposal to the North Vietnamese government to sit down at the conference table in order that the governments of the South and the North can directly seek together ways and means to end the war.

I will open wide the door of peace and leave it open to the North Vietnamese authorities in order to seek a peaceful solution to end the war which has caused sufferings to the entire Vietnamese people. This will only be achieved when the North Vietnamese government realizes that their aggressive war no longer pays off.

Many times we have made it clear that we want nothing more than the withdrawal of North Vietnam's aggressor troops and an end to their subversion and terrorism in South Vietnam. Peace will then be restored immediately.

As regards the "Front for the Liberation of the South" this should not be a preliminary condition to peace talks. As in the 1954 regroupment following the Geneva Conference, elements of the "Front" can now make a choice: Those who believe in Marxism can freely return to the North, and those who share our ideals of freedom and democracy can remain in the South and cooperate with us.

Up to now, we have welcomed more than seventy thousand returnees who have recognized that the present war is not a struggle for independence as alleged by the communists and who have decided to return to the national community so as to serve the people and rebuild the homeland. They have been treated as equals, and have been given positions suitable to their abilities. They also enjoy the same rights as any other citizen in the framework of the "National Reconciliation Policy," which we are carrying out and which will certainly succeed.

Thus far, peace has been only a frail and remote hope because the North Vietnamese regime has obstinately refused every peace settlement. In their aggressive ambition, they conceive that peace can only be realized by our surrender. For this reason, I want to make clear to the North Vietnamese government and its tools in the South that we are firmly determined to safeguard freedom and democracy. I want them to understand that they cannot use military strength to destroy these ideals and that they will not win this war.

I sincerely hope that I might meet them at a conference table in order to seek a common solution to end this war to terminate the sufferings and mournings of the peoples of both North and South Vietnam. These sufferings are due to the ambitions of those few North Vietnamese

communist leaders who obey a foreign ideology by implementing ruthless dictatorial measures.

We are not alone in our just struggle for self-defense. Nearly 40 friendly countries are actively helping us. At the same time as the American government and people are providing us their powerful assistance, the governments and peoples of the Republic of Korea, Australia, New Zealand, Thailand and the Philippines are also contributing their resources. The sacrifices of their servicemen, fighting side by side with the Vietnamese servicemen on the battlefields, have brought many important military successes, constantly improving the situation and dissipating the communists' aggressive ambitions.

Our government and people will always remain grateful to friendly countries which have helped us resist aggression, safeguard our freedom and reconstruct our country.

As for our armed forces, cadres and civil servants of every branch and level, they are also valiantly and efficiently fighting the enemy on the battlefield or in other areas of endeavor.

During the past two years, our armed forces have killed over 149,000 enemy by body count, captured more than 23,000 prisoners, and seized over 54,000 weapons of various types. In two years, 55,000 Viet-Cong have rallied to our government.

You have certainly heard of the glorious victories of the combined operations in the I Corps area, at Pleime in the II Corps area, at Phuoc-Qua in the III Corps area, and operations "Cuu-Long" and "Dan Chi" in the IV Corps area.

Concurrently with efforts to destroy the enemy, noteworthy efforts have been made in revolutionary development and rural reconstruction during the past two years: 1,978 hamlets have been built and consolidated, gathering 3,498,000 people. 4,777 classrooms, 46 maternities, 1,200 kilometers of roads, 169 bridges, 127 water-wells, 401 kilometers of canals, and 101 dikes, have been built in rural areas. Electricity has been installed in twenty localities and 42,000 peasants have been trained in farming and animal husbandry to increase production.

You have seen that our military administrative and civic cadres have made great efforts and sacrifices. Those undeniable sacrifices and efforts have made and are making history and have given us this day the promise of a better future.

Dear fellow countrymen:

The assistance of friendly countries is necessary and valuable, but we should not forget that the present struggle is above all our own struggle. Therefore, we must mobilize our entire people for the common struggle of the nation to safeguard freedom and national sovereignty.

In the present phase of the war, both the army and people must be conscious of the necessity for contributing their blood and sweat in

the common struggle. All of us must further increase our efforts in order to take initiative in the task of deciding the nation's future. We cannot depend entirely on outside assistance.

The increase of our entire people's efforts in this struggle will undoubtedly shorten the way to peace, a genuine lasting peace, that can ensure the territorial integrity and sovereignty of Vietnam in independence, freedom and democracy.

You would certainly agree with me that if the enemy is still strong it is because we are not yet stronger than he and peace cannot yet be attained for the same reason. A peace forced upon the weaker party is a surrender. I am determined not to accept a surrender. Therefore, to find a solution to the war, the first condition is to be strong in every respect. The goal of our war of self-defense and that of the communists' aggression cannot be reconciled unless we prove to the aggressors that they cannot realize their ambition.

Our all-out defense efforts do not mean that we like war and intend to destroy the population on the other side of the demarcation line. On the contrary, these efforts are made not only to restore peace in Vietnam but also to check the danger of communist aggression, maintain stability in Southeast Asia and build a durable peace for Asia and the world.

If I require from you greater efforts for defense, it is not because I advocate a military solution as the only way to defeat the communists, and overlook political, economic, cultural and social weapons. However, military strength is the preliminary condition for us to safeguard and strengthen all efforts in the above-mentioned fields in which we are striving and will succeed. Only by understanding the situation in this way will we be able to appreciate what we have to do in the future and the part that everyone has to contribute towards victory.

What I want to do is to settle the war which is the cause of sufferings and which has been ravaging our beloved country. At the same time, I will try to improve the democratic regime through the participation of the entire population in national affairs. I will also try to carry out social reforms aimed at liberating the human being and bringing the nation on the road to progress.

As I have said to you on an earlier occasion, we will have to push forward to the utmost every effort in the field of military and political activities. The entire population will thus have to accept more sacrifices and make additional efforts. Since this is a struggle for the existence of the nation, we cannot entirely rely on the assistance from friendly nations. We must first do our best in a spirit of national union. First, the armed forces must constantly be improved and reinforced. This improvement must be realized in both the morale of the troops and in their material lives in order to increase potential for defense, pacification and revolutionary development activities. This task has been intensively pushed forward since early this year and has already achieved much progress.

The reinforcement of the armed forces by the recent partial mobilization is only one of the measures intended to increase the strength of the armed forces, maintain the initiative in the battlefield, ensure security, intensify revolutionary development activities and destroy the enemy infrastructure more efficiently.

However, a strong and valiant army on the battlefield and in rural areas needs the moral support of the people and a strong popular organization in the rear and in the cities. I mean that in the rear, we must not only understand but also share the great sacrifices of the combatants and the conditions of rural people, so that they will not be grieved and feel that wartime hardships only prevail on the front and in rural areas.

I appeal to all those who are living in well-being and prosperity not to forget our war-torn country, to restrict their luxurious lives and contribute to the relief of suffering people.

A strong rear force must be organized to protect cities, relieve the heavy duties of the combatants and, at the same time, to adequately cope with the war time conditions.

In brief, to meet requirements of the war situation, to associate the rear and front lines in the efforts of a people engaged in a total war, to avoid the repetition of a shocking contrast between rural and urban areas, we cannot ask of the rural areas more hardships, greater sacrifices because the rural people are already sharing the heaviest war burden with regard to resources and manpower. This is the reason why people in the capital and other cities should make greater effort and sacrifices.

The firmer the situation in the rural area and the front-line, the more stable the situation will be in the cities and the rear. Thus, under different circumstances, the efforts and sacrifices of all people throughout the nation will be made on a fair and national basis.

In return for the efforts and the sacrifices which I ask from you, my fellow countrymen, I am determined to achieve what the government has the duty to do for the people so that we can progress from initial confidence and enthusiasm to a close cooperation between the people and the government, a voluntary acceptance of efforts and sacrifices, and complete participation in the national struggle. I believe that this is the indispensable condition to defeat the enemy, and we must honestly recognize that this has not been done sufficiently.

In the task of building democracy, although we have made great progress and established democratic institutions from the highest national level to the villages and hamlets, we have to make even greater efforts to complete the formation of the constitutional institutions as soon as possible.

As for reforming society, the establishment of a new order based on social justice—aimed at raising the standard of living as well as the educational level of the population—is the preliminary condition for the achievement of a progressive society and the raising of our country out

of its present underdeveloped state. The national policy of rural development, which is being carried out with vigor, and a plan for industrial development are the backbone of this vast undertaking.

These two tasks require both short-term and long-term plans the details of which will be presented when I introduce to you the new cabinet. However, right now, I think that a number of urgent measures to start the execution of national policy need to be taken immediately. I am referring to a number of tasks whose necessity has been recognized by all, and which a large number of our citizens of good will have mentioned, but which have not yet been accomplished.

1. On the *diplomatic* front, we will intensify our efforts to make our position clear to the world, and obtain the support of international public opinion for our cause.

2. In the *social* field, we must protect more efficiently the morals of our people. All forms of deprivation must be ended. Security and public utilities for city dwellers, especially for the population of the capital, must be guaranteed and improved.

3. In the *economic* field, we shall strive to protect the standard of living of the population, control inflation and regulate supplies. These tasks will not be easy because of communist subversion and sabotage and maneuvers of profiteers. But the government with the cooperation of the population will make every effort to obtain tangible results.

4. Nationwide *order and discipline* should be strengthened. The law should be strictly obeyed. At school, discipline should be enforced. Every citizen must understand the necessity of law and order and must do his best to cooperate with the government in this regard.

5. Together with a preparatory *military training* program, the government will create favorable conditions for students and civil servants so that they may participate efficiently in social works and devote all their capabilities to the service of the country.

6. An *austerity* program will be promoted to reduce glaring differences between the dangers and privations on the front line as well as in the countryside with blatant luxury in the cities.

7. Finally—as I have mentioned to you on an earlier occasion—in our broad aims to reform society, the major preoccupation of the government, having high priority in the first months, is the *eradication of corruption* in the governmental machinery and in the armed forces. This has to be carried out with justice, impartiality, and in broad daylight.

We have also to improve the workings of the governmental machinery, its organization, procedures, and spirit of service to the people.

The urgent measures which I have just mentioned to you must have your cooperation. Although they are only the first steps and relatively minor tasks in comparison with our overall program, they are the beginning of a journey towards a promising future.

Fellow countrymen:

From the moment I take the oath of office, I belong to you.

My preoccupations are your preoccupations. My determination to carry out my tasks should also have your determined support.

In leading the nation, I shall ask for advice from the men of talent and from the revolutionaries who have struggled for the country. I shall learn the good things from abroad without forgetting the essence of national wisdom.

At the helm of the executive, I shall accept the control of the people through the intermediary of the legislature. I shall welcome all contributions of ideas wherever they may come from. I shall also be ready to accept all responsible and constructive criticisms.

I shall not use demagoguery to lead the people into error and shall be close to the people to know the people's real aspirations.

I shall rely on your eyes to see more clearly and on your concerns to gain better knowledge.

In brief, I need the help of all the people and I consider national affairs to be the affairs of common concern of all the population, and the successes will be also those of the whole nation.

Fellow countrymen:

Today, at the dawn of a new era, a new page of history has just been opened. I earnestly hope and I have confidence that the forthcoming pages of history will inscribe the glorious achievements of our country.

History never belongs to one man or to a group of men; it belongs to the whole nation. Accordingly, historical achievements cannot be accomplished by one man or a group of men, but by all the nation.

I therefore invite you all to stand up and to contribute your share to the national struggle and reconstruction in a spirit of full cooperation between the government and the people.

Our future is decided by ourselves. Each of us has to show himself worthy of being a citizen of heroic and immortal Vietnam.

Differences always exist among men in society, but if we know how to harmonize ourselves, all our differences can be satisfactorily resolved.

If we know how to unite, to accept responsibilities and sacrifices, we will succeed in all our undertakings. I fervently ask all citizens to harmonize and unite.

Let all of us pray for peace and prosperity to come soon to our beloved Vietnam.

EMBASSY OF VIETNAM
Washington, D.C.
1968

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REPUBLIC OF VIETNAM

no. 2



PERSPECTIVES ON PEACE IN VIETNAM

By

PRESIDENT NGUYEN VAN THIEU

January 15, 1968

*This is the text of an address
made by President Nguyen Van Thieu to the
Society of Vietnamese Newspapers Editors
in Saigon on January 15, 1968*

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AN ADDRESS

by

PRESIDENT NGUYEN VAN THIEU

to

THE SOCIETY OF VIETNAMESE NEWSPAPER EDITORS

January 15, 1968

Ladies and Gentlemen,

It is a great pleasure for me to be with you, representatives of the press, as the New Year is dawning, to give you an overall review of the general situation.

The major problem which confronts us is of course the question of war or peace. We are fighting for self defense against Communist aggression, and are longing for peace in freedom and with honor. We do not ask for more, but we shall not settle for less.

In this regard, the recent statement by Nguyen-Duy-Trinh, Vice Premier of North Vietnam, has raised a great deal of speculations in this country and around the world on what North Vietnam really wants, and whether North Vietnam has softened its previous position and brought nearer the perspectives for peace.

While welcoming any moves which may open the door to peace, we have also to be vigilant and must not delude ourselves with false hopes, until we have tangible evidence of the peaceful intentions of the other side. It should be remembered that the Communists started this war, they are the aggressors. Therefore, the best indication of their willingness for peace, when it comes to materialize, should be its de-escalation of the war by the reduction of infiltration, and terrorism, as well as the scaling down of its military attacks against us. In this regard, the crude violations by the Communists of the Christmas and New Year truces a few weeks ago, portend their continued aggressive purposes, at least for the time being.

Hanoi also has not indicated any softening of its four-point platform, which is nothing less than a demand for our surrender to the Communists.

Nguyen-Duy-Trinh's statement lays emphasis on the unconditional cessation of the bombing against North Vietnam. But the bombing of

North Vietnam is an integral part of our system of defense against Communist aggression. Its purpose is to hinder the flow of infiltration into South Vietnam of men and supplies from Communist North Vietnam and to make the Communists pay a price for this aggression.

It should be recalled—and this point cannot be overstressed—that *the bombing came many years after the start of the North Vietnamese aggression, and is only a response to that aggression*. As early as June 1962, a *Special Report of the International Control Commission* testified that Communist North Vietnam had introduced a large number of men and weapons into South Vietnam, and fostered subversion and guerrilla warfare in order to overthrow the Government of South Vietnam by force, in violation of the 1954 Geneva Agreements. As a defensive measure, the bombing of North Vietnam by Allied Forces did not begin until 1965, that is more than three years after the communist aggression had started. Our patience and our restraint have been exceptional. It is therefore absurd for the Communists to require a cessation of bombing before the cessation, or at least the reduction of their aggressive activities. It is even more absurd for them to insist on an “unconditional” cessation of bombing before they condescend to contemplate possible discussions on whether or not they would be willing to stop their aggression.

It is regrettable that a segment of international public opinion has been misled by Communist propaganda into believing that the bombing is the cause of the continuation of the war. That is the confusion between the cause and the effect. The facts however are there for all to see.

It would be amusing, if it were not so tragic, to contend that a defender should stop defending himself to induce the assailant into leaving him alone.

Another preposterous argument is that we should stop bombing North Vietnam, because North Vietnam does not bomb South Vietnam and its allies. This argument disregards the fact that in this kind of war, the types of weapons and tactics are not the same on each side. The Communist used their favored tactics of infiltration, subversion, and terrorism against us. We cannot use exactly the same tactics against them. But we can use the methods of response available to us to discourage them from attacking us.

The bombing of North Vietnam is measured and gradual. It is not destined to the destruction of North Vietnam, but only to persuade the Communists to stop their aggression. In fact, *in the present context, it constitutes the only incentive for Communist North Vietnam to make peace*, otherwise the Communists can indefinitely continue guerrilla warfare, at little cost, to disrupt our society and to wear us down.

The guerrilla war in South Vietnam, even at its very beginning, is not a spontaneous movement. It is organized, directed, and supported by Hanoi. And this fact is supported by numerous and incontrovertible evidence.

The well-intentioned people who advocate the cessation of our bombing before the cessation of the Communist aggression do not realize that they contribute to the prolongation of this war.

The very fact that they advocate such a line already gives comfort to the Communists, whose favorite tactics are to exploit the divisions among free societies, to wear us down in this war of attrition.

If the Communists stop their aggression, we can have peace even without a peace conference. Conversely, if they do not give up their aggressive ambitions, even an acceptance by them to sit down at a conference table does not mean that we shall have peace.

Under the latter conditions, a Communist peace offensive may be basically a tactical move directed to these following aims:

1. By dangling the perspective of possible negotiations, the Communist aggressors try to obtain an indefinite bombing pause, which cannot be easily resumed by the United States in an election year. They will then take advantage of the bombing pause to increase their infiltration of men and supplies, and to rebuild their bases and staging areas for further attacks against us.

2. By placing emphasis on the bombing in North Vietnam alone, they try to make separate issues of the war in the North, and the war in the South, and promote their propaganda line that for the war below the 17th parallel, the Allies have to negotiate with their instrument, the so-called "National Liberation Front." This is a scheme for them to obtain acceptance of a "coalition government," in which the Communist elements, as Trojan horses, will gradually take over the whole of South Vietnam.

3. The Communists also use the strategem of addressing themselves to the United States Government only, while omitting the Government of the Republic of Vietnam to reverse the positions and place our Allies in the role of aggressors and interventionists.

This is our country. We are victims of Communist aggression and we requested help and assistance from friendly countries many years after the aggression had started. The friendly countries which have come to our help, do so out of common security in the face of Communist expansion, and out of common ideals for freedom. *The Republic of Vietnam most naturally should have the central role in any developments relating to the events in Vietnam.* To overlook or to disregard this normal setup is to give leeway to the Communist tendentious propaganda, and damage the success of our common cause.

I regret to say that in the past our Allies sometimes have not avoided these pitfalls, by placing themselves at the center of peace efforts on Vietnam, for instance by asking the United Nations or other governments to help solve the Vietnamese problem, while *such a move should be made by the government of Vietnam, as the principal party, with the support of all allied and friendly countries.*

Now that the Republic of Vietnam has a duly elected government, our position will be stronger than before, and I am confident that our allies will no longer let the Communists confuse international public opinion any further on the basic issue of this war.

We shall have genuine peace the day when the Communists are convinced that the price they have to pay for their aggression is too high, in a war that they cannot win.

In this regard, we have achieved encouraging results last year by wiping out most of the Communist bases inside South Vietnam. Without these bases, it is very difficult for both the regular Communist units and the Communist guerrillas to operate against us. The Communists therefore have to rely increasingly on bases and staging areas from across our borders, especially those inside Cambodian territory.

Prince Sihanouk himself admitted the presence of Vietnamese Communist troops inside Cambodia, although he minimized their number and the duration of their stay in Cambodia. He may not even know the extent of communist violation of Cambodian territory, or he does not want to know.

In our defense against aggression, however, we cannot tolerate that the Vietnamese Communists use Cambodian territory as a sanctuary to launch attacks against us. The Vietnamese Communists have consistently violated Cambodian neutrality, with or without the consent of the Cambodian authorities. This situation will have to end, one way or another. We respect the independence and the territorial integrity of Cambodia, but we fully reserve the right of pursuit against the communist aggressors if they continue to use staging areas in Cambodia.

In recent months, the Cambodian Government has urged other Governments to recognize the frontiers of Cambodia, and even made such a recognition a condition for the maintenance of diplomatic relations with Cambodia.

The territorial integrity of Cambodia is menaced by no one. But the demarcation line of the frontiers between Cambodia and Vietnam is very confused in the areas occupied by marshes and jungles. In other areas, the sign posts are often inexistent or were displaced in a haphazard fashion. Even on the maps made by the former French Geographic Service, the border line varies, depending on the scales of the maps.

This confusion has led to a number of border incidents between Cambodia and Vietnam in the last decade. Consequently, the Vietnamese Government in 1964 proposed the establishment of a Mixed Commission, in which both Vietnamese and Cambodian experts would determine, on the basis of existing documents, the border line and then demarcate on the terrain the frontier line which has been agreed upon. Arbitrators chosen by common agreement would decide in case of litigation.

But for reasons difficult to understand, Prince Sihanouk obstinately refused this procedure.

We feel that any recognition of Cambodian frontiers is meaningful only when there is greater certainty on where the border line is, through the whole extent of the frontiers, and we maintain our offer for a Mixed Commission to solve amicably this question with our Cambodian neighbors.

The Republic of Vietnam has friendly dispositions toward Cambodia, and has interest in an independent and genuinely neutral Cambodia. Logically, Cambodia also should have interest in an independent and free Vietnam, because if the Communists took over the whole of Vietnam, Cambodia cannot survive very long. Prince Sihanouk himself recognized this fact. And yet, strangely enough, he seems to seek survival for his country by courting the favors of Hanoi and Peking, and find comfort in the communist verbal assurances that they might respect Cambodian territory and independence. In doing so, Prince Sihanouk is courting disaster for Cambodia. The Vietnamese Communists now in Cambodia may never want to leave, as has been shown by the sad experience of the Laotians with the Pathet-Lao.

In a very delicate and dangerous situation, Prince Sihanouk has been constantly shifting his attitude on a number of issues and is particularly prone to the practice of diplomacy by insults.

I can only hope that the Cambodian authorities will come soon to grasp with realities, and will adopt a line of policy more consonant with long range Cambodian interests, and in a more dignified style suitable to a nation which boasts of an ancient civilization.

To prevent communist violation of Cambodian neutrality, the International Control Commission has not sufficient strength to cope with the problem. Moreover, it is paralyzed by the lack of cooperation of Communist Poland in this troika system.

The best solution seems to be the establishment of an *International Police Force*, as the Republic of Vietnam has proposed to the United Nations in the summer of 1964, when Cambodia brought up the question of border incidents before the Security Council. Such an International Police Force should include only members from truly neutral nations, to avoid obstructions.

Such a formula, proposed by the Republic of Vietnam, was initially accepted by Prince Sihanouk in 1964, but in a characteristic manner he subsequently changed his mind and thereby thwarted a constructive solution which can most efficiently guarantee the territorial integrity as well as the neutrality of his country, and keep the war away from Cambodia.

Today, this door to peace and amity is still open, and we earnestly hope that Prince Sihanouk will not disregard this opportunity at this critical juncture.

While fighting with determination to defend our freedom, we do not spare our efforts to explore all the possibilities which could bring this war rapidly to a peaceful conclusion. I have already initiated steps in that direction.

We regret that the United Nations could not play a more active role in the reestablishment of peace and security in this area. The main reason is the negative attitude of the Peking and the Hanoi regimes vis-a-vis the United Nations. As you remember, in August 1964 when the question of the Tonkin Gulf incidents was brought before the United Nations, the Security Council invited both the Republic of Vietnam and the Hanoi regime to present their respective viewpoints to the Council. Hanoi rejected this invitation, and chimed in with Peking in declaring that the United Nations is not competent to deal with this question. Such an attitude is not surprising on the part of the Peking regime which cannot, by any yardstick, be considered a peace-loving regime. In fact, it still stands indicted of aggression by the United Nations for its role in the Korean war. As for the Hanoi regime, it is well known that it is submissive to the Peking line of policy.

But we could have expected the Secretary General of the United Nations to support a more active role for the world organization in the war in Vietnam. The fact that the principal parties to this conflict are not members of the United Nations is not, by itself, an overriding obstacle to this solution, provided the interested parties accept to adhere to the principles of the United Nations Charter.

Secretary General U Thant personally has shown an active interest in the Vietnam war. We only hope that he will find it possible to make a visit to Vietnam to have first-hand information, and to acquaint himself better with the complex Vietnamese situation which is very different from the situation in Burma at the time of the communist rebellion there in 1948. He may also usefully visit other countries in Southeast Asia to find out there how people really feel about the war in Vietnam, and what the struggle here, in Vietnam, means to them. From a distance, the issues are often obscured and the so-called National Liberation Front might acquire a certain flavor of nationalism which it does not have.

I do not doubt the genuine concern for peace of Secretary General U Thant. I believe therefore that he owes it to himself, and to the United Nations, to have more complete and first-hand information on this subject. Only under these conditions could he play the role of an impartial and enlightened mediator in this conflict.

Red China leaves Burma and India alone, for the time being, not because of the magic formula of 'neutralism' in these countries. The day of reckoning will come when and if the lines of defense against communism crumble in Southeast Asia. In fact, by our defense against communist aggression in Vietnam, we help 'neutralism' to endure in this part of the world.

As for the Republic of Vietnam, we have stated many times that as soon as the communist aggression stops and there are sufficient guarantees against further communist aggression, we shall request all foreign troops to leave. Besides, Allied troops also are anxious to go home as soon as the danger of communist aggression ceases to exist.

The Republic of Vietnam is not inclined to systematically align itself with any country in the world. But we are willing and ready to be on friendly terms and in constructive cooperation with any country, on the basis of mutual respect for one another's sovereignty and freedom.

In the present juncture, facing the future, I believe that communist expansion cannot be checked simply by our appeal to the reasonableness of the aggressors, but rather by clear evidence to them that they cannot win, and will have to pay a high price for their aggression.

All possibilities for peace should be thoroughly explored. But after a reasonable time, if the communist aggressors remain adamant, *heavier pressure* against them will become necessary.

The communists count on our weariness. They also count on the exploitation of an ill-informed and emotional public opinion in free countries to create opposition to our defense efforts. Last but not least, the Communists direct their efforts to the disruption of our society in South Vietnam through the constant pressures of war, with its inevitable consequences of inflation, high costs of living, social and economic disturbances. A war of attrition will play into their hands. A more energetic response against the communist aggressors therefore seems necessary, unless a peaceful conclusion of the war is within sight.

We should maintain our unshakeable determination to defend freedom. We must do much more to meet this momentous challenge, by making greater efforts, and accepting greater discipline and greater sacrifices.

No war can be won without sweat, tears, and blood.

This war cannot be won unless the Republic of Vietnam is more respected by friends and foes, and this cannot be achieved until we deserve it.

This is a common responsibility for all of us. We should strive for the establishment of a healthier, better motivated, and more disciplined society.

Some of our countrymen may be inclined to think, "Now that we are building democracy, what rights should I have and make prevail?" But we should think also, and think more of our duties toward the country, and of the obligations that we should assume to establish a sound and progressive democracy. We should forget our petty quarrels to learn to live and work together in harmony for the building of a stronger and more prosperous society.

In this great task, the members of the press can play a very important role by laying greater emphasis on the thoughtful and constructive discussions of major issues of national interest, and providing better and better information in terms of facts and figures on the important problems confronting the nation in order to enlighten public opinion.

On the threshold of the New Year, it is a propitious time for all of us to rededicate ourselves to the high ideals which have accounted for many glorious pages in our long history, and I am glad to take this opportunity to wish to you all a very Happy New Year.

EMBASSY OF VIETNAM
Washington, D.C.
1968

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REPUBLIC OF VIETNAM



ON PEACE AND MANPOWER REQUIREMENTS

By

PRESIDENT NGUYEN VAN THIEU

April 10, 1968

*This is the text of an address
made by President Nguyen Van Thieu to the
Joint Session of the National Assembly on
April 10, 1968*

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AN ADDRESS

by

PRESIDENT NGUYEN VAN THIEU

to

THE JOINT SESSION OF THE NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

April 10, 1968

Mr. President of the Senate,
Mr. President of the House,
Distinguished Senators and Representatives,
Ladies and Gentlemen:

Ten days ago, on the inauguration of the first regular legislative session of 1968 and the first anniversary of the promulgation of the Constitution, I sent you a message in which I reviewed the situation of the nation following the Tet general offensive of the communists. During the past ten days, there has been a pause in the bombing of a major part of the territory of the north, and the North Vietnamese authorities have agreed to send representatives to explore the possibility of holding peace talks. These are viewed as important events in the situation.

Within my position and competence, I have constantly pursued the national policy of achieving peace in independence, democracy, and progress in reaching decisions on proper attitudes and actions. As for the legislature, the two houses have also adopted many appropriate and clear-sighted resolutions. This uniformity of will and views and the prompt and harmonious actions of the Legislative and the Executive in the face of the changing situation should be recorded as an achievement which we jointly have been able to make in the process of our present struggle and long-term national reconstruction.

I believe that our legislative and executive branches should maintain and reinforce this uniformity of will and views to further strengthen our position and our forces. At the same time, this will help accelerate the democracy-building efforts and further heighten the level of our development. This is my belief, and I hope that this is the principal view in today's meeting between the Legislative and the Executive.

Ladies and Gentlemen,

I am convinced all you in the two Houses as well as all our compatriots have given special attention to the recent developments in the situation. In addition to the news that the press and other information media have disseminated since the first of April, on behalf of the government I have also tried to present the situation in various ways so that all our compatriots can better understand it. On April second, I held a press conference to present my decisions and explain my position. On April fourth, the government issued a communique on the Republic of Vietnam's stand with regard to recent developments. Also on April fourth, I invited the two Presidents and the Foreign Relations Committee Chairmen of the two Houses to come to the Independence Palace so that I could explain the government's position. I will maintain these close contacts with the two Houses in dealing with the new developments, and I am ready to accept your close cooperation during the present difficult and decisive period.

Ladies and Gentlemen,

Today, first of all, I wish to explain to you and the entire population the position of the Republic of Vietnam Government. The Republic of Vietnam Government's position is clear to everybody. In the inauguration ceremony last October and in a message to the assembly on January 25, 1968, I stated that while we were devoting all our efforts and making all necessary sacrifices for the defense of freedom against communist aggression, we would not neglect any opportunity or initiative that can bring true and lasting peace to our country.

In this search for a true and lasting peace, there has been complete harmony of thought between us and the allied countries. Our common goal at present as well as in the past is *peace in freedom*. At the Manila Summit Conference in October 1966, the seven allied countries unanimously stated in a joint communique that they share the same will and determination to guarantee the freedom of South Vietnam. In their determination to seek peace and in their special concern for the future of the Asian and Pacific countries and to reach this goal, these countries will determinedly continue their military efforts regardless of the time needed through close exchanges of views until the aggression ends. In addition, the allied countries also stated in the communique that the search for peace must proceed until a just and appropriate solution is reached.

In line with this common policy, we have agreed to de-escalate the air raids against the North to show our good will for peace and hope that our antagonists will respond with equal good will in order to create favorable conditions for peace talks. The air raids continue in the area from the 20th parallel south to the demilitarized zone, where the enemy movement of troops and supplies is a serious and direct threat to the

allied positions. In deciding on a partial halt of the bombing against the North before the communists de-escalate their aggression, we have clearly taken a calculated risk in our search for peace.

The Government of Vietnam will be in close consultations with the Government of the United States and other Allied Governments regarding the contacts to be undertaken with the North Vietnamese authorities for the purpose of exploring the possibilities for eventual negotiations to end the war. Here I wish to state that the coming contacts will not have the character of a peace conference and does not have the character of a peace conference, but are only exploratory contacts to determine conditions which may lead to the holding of a peace conference in the future. And the governments of the allied countries have agreed to consult each other regularly on any important point or any decision during the coming contacts. This point was confirmed in the third section of the April fourth communique of our government and is consistent with the spirit of the Manila Summit Conference.

On January 15, 1968 the United States Government restated its pledge never to unilaterally take any action concerning negotiations without prior consultations with us. Last week, I convened in Saigon a meeting of the Ambassadors of the allied countries participating in the war to examine the general situation and take common actions. I feel that this formula is necessary and reasonable.

The United States President has invited me to visit the United States, and I am now considering this invitation. Although I have not yet decided on the timing of this state visit, I think that top-level meetings between the allied governments will be very useful in the forthcoming crucial period and that, more than ever, solidarity and understanding among the allied nations is necessary.

Ladies and Gentlemen,

We all agree that the communists cannot gain a military victory because they cannot defeat the Vietnamese and allied forces. Therefore, they will concentrate all their efforts on gaining at the conference table what they cannot achieve on the battlefield.

The communists suffered severe losses during their Tet general offensive and the subsequent counterattacks by our forces and the allied forces throughout the country. It will be difficult for them to replace their losses, and this will certainly take time. In this abortive general offensive, the communists not only received severe blows from our forces and the allied forces but also encountered strong opposition from the Vietnamese people. They were victims of their own deceitful propaganda in believing that the people would rise up at the very outset to oppose our government and troops.

These severe setbacks certainly forced the Hanoi government to partially soften its previous absurd demand that the allied countries

unilaterally and unconditionally cease all bombing raids in the North and stop all other acts of war north of the 17th parallel before peace negotiations could be considered, as it has often stated. In its April third statement, the Hanoi authorities stated that their demands were not properly and completely met. However, they are willing to meet the United States to talk about the unconditional cessation of the bombing and other hostile acts against the North in order to open the way for peace talks.

The Hanoi authorities may resume the old communist trick of fighting while negotiating, which means they may continue to fight, on one hand, and, on the other, accept peace talks to obtain a suspension of activities on our part and to cover up their increased military preparations for future attacks. Later on, when they achieve their military buildup, they might launch another general offensive under the pretext that the preliminary talks failed to bring about the expected results. The communists will do their utmost to achieve some military success in order to have a strong military position at the conference table, in line with their well-known strategy of fighting along while negotiating. Therefore, we should heighten our vigilance and be prepared to cope with all new attacks by the communist aggressors.

In reaching a peace settlement, we must examine carefully the following important points:

First, although we have taken the first step in stopping the bombing over a large part of North Vietnam, it is obvious that any peaceful settlement of an armed conflict requires mutual steps toward de-escalation. We cannot accept and will never accept the unconditional cessation of the bombing as demanded by the North Vietnamese authorities in their April third statement. Whether or not North Vietnam deescalates the war will constitute the acid test of whether or not it genuinely wishes to enter into meaningful peace negotiations. In this situation, we must pay attention to the communist trick of false de-escalation. For instance, they might withdraw a number of troops from the Khe Sanh area, in order to use these troops more effectively in some other place in the first corps. Or, when they lack strength and are training more troops, or when they are constantly counterattacked by our troops and cannot initiate any operation, they may depict themselves as having good will and having deescalated the war. If the communists want to show good will in response to the curtailment of the bombing over a large part of the North, they should withdraw their troops from South Vietnam and reduce their aggressive and terroristic activities in South Vietnam.

Second, the bombing of the North is only a response to the aggression of the North against the Republic of Vietnam. We cannot allow Hanoi to differentiate between the military activities of the allies in the North and Hanoi's aggressive activities in the South, because their aggressive activities are the cause of the present war. Therefore, a cur-

tailment or cessation of the bombing of North Vietnam must go hand-in-hand with a curtailment and cessation of the aggressive activities of the communists in the Republic of Vietnam, including the infiltration of troops and weapons from the North and the armed attacks and sabotage activities organized and directed by the Hanoi authorities.

Third, peace talks must be prompt and productive. On this point, we entirely agree with President Johnson's San Antonio formula. We cannot let the communists take advantage of a curtailment in the bombing to strengthen their military bases and improve their supply system, and make preparations for further aggressive acts.

Fourth, if and when preliminary contacts lead to formal peace talks, the Republic of Vietnam should naturally play the principal role in the talks because the communist aggression has directly affected the Republic of Vietnam and the participation of the allied countries in this war was in response to our call. The communist tendentious propaganda has always drummed up the line that our allied friends have intervened in our internal affairs and have invaded our country. The Republic of Vietnam suffered communist aggression to a great extent for many years before we called for allied assistance to cope with the ever increasing aggressive pleasures of communist imperialism. Overlooking the fact that the Republic of Vietnam plays a principal role in the present war for self defense is tantamount to giving political advantage to the communists and jeopardizing the just cause, as I have often stated.

Fifth, we do not and will not accept the participation of the so-called South Vietnam National Liberation Front as a valid participant at any stage of the peace talks, even in the preliminary contacts. As is well known, this organization is just a facade and a tool of Hanoi. This fact has been clearly proven by the legal committee of the International Control Commission.

The perfidious communist scheme is to strive for international recognition of this organization at the conference table as an entity different from Hanoi. This is the enemy's first step toward a coalition government in South Vietnam in which the tool of Hanoi will play the role of a Trojan horse in order to seize the Republic of Vietnam through subversive political methods. For these reasons, we have affirmed that we will not approve a coalition government formula with the so-called National Liberation Front. Facts show that East European countries which adopted this coalition formula have suffered tragic results. We ourselves also had this experience in 1945 and 1946. The results of this formula would be the liquidation of nationalist elements and the complete seizure of the country through ruthless and cruel communist maneuvers. We should not forget that communism never accepts a coalition government as a permanent solution but only as a temporary tactic leading to the gradual liquidation of the nationalist elements.

Aware of this danger, the foreign ministers of the allied countries participating in the Seven-Nation Conference in Wellington to discuss

the Vietnam problem expounded the following views on this matter in the April first joint communique: "The Ministers agreed that the South Vietnamese people must be assured of the right to determine their own future through democratic and constitutional process without either external interference or terrorist pressure. The imposition of any form of government, including the spurious 'coalition' advocated by the communists and some others, would be incompatible with this principle and therefore completely unacceptable".

Indeed, if communist aggression is allowed to win through devious political means, the sacrifices of many of our compatriots and combatants as well as those of the allied countries will have become meaningless.

Moreover, for years our policy has consisted of stretching out our arms to welcome back the combatants on the other side who have put down their weapons and decided to join us, as law-abiding citizens, and cooperated with us in accordance with a democratic and constitutional formula in order to advance toward a respect for human dignity and toward achieving a lasting peace prosperity for the country. More than 78,000 combatants from the other side of the frontline have rallied to our cause and enjoyed our warm welcome. These people are contributing to our difficult task of rebuilding the nation. It is my earnest hope that through this vast program of National Reconciliation we may restore a just peace in our war-torn country, heal our wounds, rebuild our nation, and combine all our efforts and the national resources to build our country into a free, independent, and prosperous nation.

The path leading to peace will have a great many difficulties and obstacles as long as Hanoi sticks to its expansionist and aggressive designs. I do not feel too optimistic over our enemy's reply for they are extremely stubborn and cunning. I consider the North Vietnamese communists' answer a good and significant sign, but we should not be over-optimistic. On the contrary, we should be careful and cautious, for, as I have repeatedly stated, the communists always consider peace talks as part of their aggressive war designs. In war or in peace talks, we should always be vigilant, especially during peace talks. More than ever, we should be prepared and clear-sighted in dealing with all schemes of the enemy.

Thus, even when we are searching for peace, we should also more than ever increase our fighting capacity. We should do this so we may have sufficient strength to talk with the communists. Moreover, the communists will only accept peace when they see our real strength and realize that they will never be able to win the war even if they resort to all wicked and cruel schemes.

Our present build-up in all aspects will certainly be an important contribution to peace. At the same time, it will enable us to be prepared to cope with all other schemes of the enemy in the days ahead should the communists once again stubbornly destroy all hopes for peace.

To achieve our plan for increasing the fighting capacity of the nation, apart from the measures applied by the government within its authority and capacity, we deem it necessary to resort to a general mobilization of manpower and national resources in the days ahead to meet the requirements of the situation. I have decided to propose a general mobilization to the National Assembly. The draft law on general mobilization has been submitted to the Secretariat of the Lower House for debate and approval by the National Assembly. I respectfully ask the National Assembly to debate and approve this draft law with an enthusiastic spirit and in accordance with the emergency procedures. I expect that the two Houses will approve this draft law promptly and completely and provide a strong support for our efforts in the struggle as well as in the peace approach.

Ladies and gentlemen,

I have given you an account of the situation and requested the two Houses to pass the draft law on general mobilization which has been submitted to the Lower House and which can serve as a strong support for us in the war as well as in the peace talks. However, the mobilization problem presents another feature which cannot be realized through the enactment of any law: This is spiritual and political mobilization, which is an urgent problem and a national requirement. How to fulfill this requirement will depend greatly on the representatives in the two Houses who were directly elected by the people. The problem consists of finding a way to mobilize the people spiritually and politically. You are elected representatives of the people and therefore should be entrusted with this mission. I expect that spiritual and political mobilization will be achieved not only in this institution but also among all branches, all circles, all organizations, all associations, and all compatriots throughout the country. I appeal to all our people to stand up, unite, close ranks, and to strongly voice their desires for peace in independence, democracy, and progress. Our entire people are eager for peace, independence, democracy and progress. So, with all our strength, we should all contribute to the achievement of these noble objectives. With the solidarity and efforts of our 14 million compatriots, I firmly believe that we will score glorious successes, win over any enemy, overcome any obstacles, and achieve peace and prosperity.

Ladies and gentlemen,

In the message addressed to you on April first I pointed out that we are facing a situation full of challenges and opportunities. Today, I want to remind you of this. Certainly, you realize that in this situation, we will have to meet more challenges, but the opportunities will be greater and more brilliant. Everything depends on us alone. Whether we are able to overcome all difficulties and hardships and open up magnificent opportunities depends greatly upon the actions, the will, and the attitude of

the members of the two Houses in the days to come. The history of our race and the souls of our forefathers and fallen heroes will help us overcome today's challenges on our way toward a glorious and victorious tomorrow. I convey my thanks and salutations to you all.

**EMBASSY OF VIETNAM
Washington, D.C.
1968**

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REPUBLIC OF VIET-NAM

PEACE AND BEYOND

OFFICIAL STATEMENTS AND COMMUNIQUE

on

PEACE AND POSTWAR DEVELOPMENT

July - September 1968

VIET-NAM DOCUMENTS SERIES IV

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THE PERSPECTIVE OF PEACE

STATEMENT

of

H.E. MR. TRAN CHANH THANH

FOREIGN MINISTER OF THE REPUBLIC OF VIET-NAM

30 July 1968

Mr. Chairman,
Distinguished Delegates,

The Vietnamese Delegation welcomes this opportunity to exchange views with the other members of the Council on questions that are affecting our region. Since the meeting of the Council last year, the tension in our area has increased. North Viet-Nam has suddenly accelerated the tempo of her aggression against the Republic of Viet-Nam, and against Laos. This has happened in face of the cessation of Allied bombing on most of North Viet-Nam's territory, and of the preliminary talks now underway between the United States of America and Hanoi in Paris.

On January 31st this year, the communist forces launched a series of coordinated attacks against Saigon and several other cities of South Viet-Nam, treacherously breaking their truce. These attacks marked a drastic change of strategy. Up to then, the communists directed their action mainly towards the rural countryside where most of our population live and where the bulk of our national wealth comes from. From 1959, when they started in earnest their armed aggression against the South, until the beginning of 1968, their aim was—in their own words —“to take over the rural countryside in order to encircle the cities”.

That strategy, pursued during nine long years, has proved to be a failure.

The Communists then concentrated all their efforts on attacking the cities. Having declared a seven-day truce on the occasion of the Lunar New Year, they treacherously broke it to launch their so-called “general offensive and general uprising.”

Captured documents and statements of returnees and prisoners of war showed that the enemy's intention was to create psychological conditions for eventual negotiations. By attacking the towns, he hoped to trigger a popular revolt and to create such a critical situation as to force our Government to accept his peace conditions.

In May there was a second communist offensive, timed to coincide with the start of the preliminary talks in Paris. Compared to the first, the second one was much weaker, but it had one notable feature: the indiscriminate bombing by rockets of populated areas.

Both offensives failed. The constitutional regime of the Republic of Viet-Nam, set up by last year's free elections, remained intact. Faced with its most severe trial, the Vietnamese Army had risen to the challenge and emerged from it stronger, more self-confident. The Viet-Cong never received the popular support they expected. Moreover, they have alienated the people. Their mass killings, as shown by the common graves near Hue, each containing hundreds of bodies; their murder even of foreigners like the three German professors of Hue University and their wives, or the five press correspondents in Saigon, the destruction of civilian areas by rockets; all this has been deeply resented by our people.

Our assessment of the actual situation is as follows: North Viet-Nam has changed her strategy of conquest at the beginning of this year because the former strategy has not succeeded. The new communist strategy, based on an intensification of hostilities directed against the cities is a short-term one. It has been very costly to the aggressors in terms of both men and equipment.

During the first six months of this year, they suffered about 100,000 fatalities. The kill ratio was 9:1 compared to our casualties.

It is unlikely that North Viet-Nam, with her seventeen million population, and her underdeveloped economy, can sustain this level of losses for very long, even with massive help from Red China and Soviet Russia. During the first half of this year 91,000 North Vietnamese troops have infiltrated into the South. The territory of Laos and Cambodia has increasingly been used as a corridor of infiltration and as a base of aggression. North Vietnamese now comprise over 70% of the communist main force battalions in the South, as compared to 26% three years ago. This huge expeditionary army must be supplied with munitions, equipment, food. This is the reason why in our assessment, the new communist strategy is, and can only be, one aimed at a short-term objective. If the objective cannot be reached soon, then the new strategy will have failed.

Over the last month, there has been a lull in the ground fighting, as well as in the rocket bombing of the cities. It is a fact that our forces have been successful in blocking the enemy's moves. But there are also indications that they are regrouping for a new offensive. Even if they have the capability to do so, our forces are ready to meet, and to defeat them.

The coming period will thus be crucial. To meet the new situation created by the increased aggression from North Viet-Nam, our Government has decreed total mobilization. Our Armed Forces will have reached 800,000 by the end of the year. In addition, there will be 200,000 men in the police and self-defense forces. Alongside the quantitative increase in manpower, the equipment of our forces will also be improved. . . . All the troops down to the self-defense forces at hamlet level will be supplied with the M-16 rifle during 1969. They will then be able to shoulder a larger part of the burden of the war.

The rural development programme has known some local setbacks because of the communist offensives. We are, however, rapidly recovering, and it is expected that the program will soon be back to pre-offensive level. There are at present 46,000 rural development cadres. An increase of 16,000 cadres is planned for the second half of 1968.

On the political field, an earnest effort is being made to consolidate our democratic regime by the formation of well-organized and broadly-based parties. Our constitution has expressed a preference for a two-party system. There is now a movement to merge the existing parties into two big groups, one supporting the Government and the other standing in opposition. The present phase of our struggle is one of resistance against armed aggression. However, the long-term challenge facing us is of a political character. And that challenge will be the establishment of a stable democracy so that ultimately we will be able to guarantee our own independence and freedom.

Now I would like to discuss the Paris talks.

By accepting to come to the conference table, the communists have shown that they have abandoned their hope to achieve outright military victory in Viet-Nam. They have changed their tactics, but their objective remains the same. What they have been doing in Paris for the last two months is to follow the familiar line of "talking while fighting". North Viet-Nam's attitude has been negative. She has not responded to the major limitation of the bombing on her territory. She has continued to deny the evidence of North Vietnamese troops fighting in the South. In this situation what is required from our side is to be vigilant, patient, and to keep up the pressure on the battlefield until the time when the aggressor will see reason.

Hanoi's attitude in Paris will depend on the outcome of the battlefield in Viet-Nam. It will also depend on the attitude of two countries, without whose help Hanoi could not have started its aggression: Red China and Soviet Russia.

Red China is opposed to all forms of negotiations. The cold reception given to Xuan Thuy in Peking on his way to attend the Paris talks,

as well as the reported attacks on the North Vietnamese consular missions in Nanking and Kwangchow, showed the hard line taken by Peking.

As for Soviet Russia, I think that she has a stake in the stability of our area. She could make North Viet-Nam more amenable to a peaceful solution. She has powerful means to do so. However, up to now there has been no sign showing that Soviet Russia is effectively working towards peace in Viet-Nam.

Many rumors have been circulating about the Paris talks, to the effect that the United States of America are going to unilaterally stop the bombing over the whole of North Viet-Nam, that they are going to accept a coalition government in South Viet-Nam. Statements made both by President Nguyen Van Thieu and President Johnson at their recent Honolulu meeting have shown that these rumors are unfounded. As a matter of fact, just to propagate rumors like these is to fall into the communist trap, for the communist propaganda has presented this war as the result of American intervention in the affairs of Asia. The truth is that this is a Vietnamese war. The United States of America, as well as the other Allies, are in South Viet-Nam only to help us fight aggression, in answer to our call.

The bombing of North Viet-Nam is not the cause of the war. It is only a reaction against aggression, a measure of self-defense aimed at reducing the flow of troops and materials from North Viet-Nam into the South. In spite of this, our side has made the first step and stopped the bombing on most of North Vietnamese territory. It is now North Viet-Nam's turn to deescalate. She could do so by respecting the status of the Demilitarized Zone, by reducing the infiltration, and by respecting the neutrality of Laos as stipulated in the 1962 agreements. The absence of rocket bombing on Saigon during the last month cannot be taken as an act of deescalation on the communist side, it is merely the result of more effective security measures taken by our forces.

The present talks in Paris are preliminary in character. Whenever substantial negotiations begin, the two principal parties must naturally be the two Viet-Nams. South Viet-Nam's leading role in the negotiations has been stressed by the U.S. President at Honolulu.

Moreover, we have appealed many times to North Viet-Nam to open bilateral talks in order to settle this conflict among ourselves. But Hanoi has kept silent.

At the Honolulu meeting, our President has set out the conditions of peace in Viet-Nam in the following terms:

—The reestablishment of the 17th Parallel as the demarcation line between South and North Viet-Nam, pending a determination, by the

free choice of all Vietnamese, on reunification;

—Respect for the territorial integrity of the Republic of Viet-Nam;

—Full compliance with the principle of non-interference between South and North Viet-Nam;

—The withdrawal from South Viet-Nam of all military and subversive forces from the North;

—An end to aggression and a complete cessation of hostilities throughout Viet-Nam;

—Effective international supervision and guarantees for the carrying out and preservation of the above measures.

There could be a cease-fire on the basis of these conditions and as part of a final settlement. We are prepared to meet immediately with representatives of Hanoi to discuss the arrangements for a cease-fire.

As for the internal affairs of South Viet-Nam, we subscribe to the democratic principle of one-man one-vote. All individuals and members of groups who agree to renounce force and to abide by our Constitution could fully participate in political activities.

The "National Liberation Front of South Viet-Nam" is, as its name indicates, only a front behind which Hanoi carries out its policy of conquest. It has no representative character. The Legal Committee of the International Commission for Supervision and Control has concluded in a report dated June, 1962, that the "Front" was led and controlled by Hanoi. There can be no question of us negotiating with the "Front", or entering into a coalition with it. Nor is there any possibility for the "Front" to be allowed to function as a political party in the South. The recently formed "Alliance for Democracy and Peace" is but an offspring of the "Front", created to deceive public opinion.

The internal problems of South Viet-Nam are for our people to decide. To put an end to the erroneous rumors made about us and our ally, the United States, on this subject, allow me to quote President Johnson: "The United States will not support the imposition of a Coalition Government, or any other form of Government, on the people of South Viet-Nam." (Honolulu Joint Communique)

Vietnam is not an isolated case. Other countries in our area, Laos, Thailand, Cambodia, Malaysia, Indonesia, are also threatened with overt or camouflaged aggression. This aggression comes from the same source, and not limited to any one country. Communism is trying to expand in Asia, through the strategy of "wars of national liberation." It is difficult for a small country to face it alone. A common threat must be met by common action. This is the reason why Allied troops are fighting in South Viet-Nam.

What we want is the end of aggression and the restoration of the *status quo ante*. Once peace is achieved, we are prepared to coexist peacefully with North Viet-Nam. Going even further, we would consider favorably the gradual development of relations beneficial to both South Viet-Nam and North Viet-Nam, subject only to the essential safeguards against renewed subversion. Such a course of action would lead to the ultimate reunification of our country, in peace, freedom and progress.

Mr. Chairman,
Distinguished Delegates,

I have taken much time in talking at length about Viet-Nam because I believe the developments of the war in Viet-Nam are affecting the whole ASPAC area. Thank you very much for your patience.

JOINT COMMUNIQUE

Third Ministerial Meeting

ASIAN AND PACIFIC COUNCIL

Canberra, Australia

30 July - 1 August 1968

§1. At the invitation of the Government of Australia, the Third Ministerial Meeting of the Asian Pacific Council, comprising Australia, the Republic of China, Japan, the Republic of Korea, Malaysia, New Zealand, the Philippines, Thailand and the Republic of Viet-Nam met in Canberra, Australia, from 30 July to 1 August 1968. An observer from the Kingdom of Laos attended all sessions of the Meeting.

§2. In his opening address, the Australian Prime Minister, the Right Honourable J. G. Gorton, welcomed the delegates. Noting that ASPAC included many important countries of the Asian and Pacific region, the Prime Minister emphasised that, although the organization was only two years old, it had made significant progress towards the attainment of its fundamental goal, namely, the creation of a relationship of practical co-operation and understanding in political, economic, cultural and social fields among member countries.

§3. The Ministers over a period of three days discussed a wide range of world and regional problems.

§4. In their exchange of views, the Ministers considered such subjects as the non-proliferation of nuclear weapons, nuclear testing and disarmament; the politics of the major powers in relation to the region and relations between the major powers as they affect the region; the need for security as a foundation for political stability and economic progress; the world economic situation and its bearings on the economic development of member nations; and the political and economic problems of the region itself. The problems arising out of developments on the Chinese mainland were of particular concern to Ministers and they agreed that this situation was uncertain and should be closely followed.

§5. The Ministers expressed concern over the increased infiltration of armed agents into the Republic of Korea including the 21 January incident, and noted with satisfaction the efforts being made by the Government and people of the Republic of Korea to preserve their national independence and to continue the rapid development of the national economy.

§6. The Ministers noted with satisfaction the development of democratic institutions even during wartime in the Republic of Viet-Nam since last year's Meeting of the Council, and the increased efforts that this country is making in the military, rural development and political fields in order to defend itself better. They reaffirmed their sympathy for and support to the people and Government of the Republic of Viet-Nam in their struggle to defend themselves and to preserve their sovereign independence, territorial integrity and the right to decide their own affairs.

§7. The Ministers took note of the present talks in Paris between representatives of the United States and North Viet-Nam and expressed the ardent hope that these talks would open the way to negotiations, in which the Republic of Viet-Nam would naturally play a leading role, for a just, honourable and lasting peace.

§8. Looking ahead to the days when the war is over and peace and freedom are secured, they acknowledged the need for common efforts on a broad international basis to help in the rehabilitation and development of the Republic of Viet-Nam and other countries affected by the war.

§9. The Ministers considered the progress that had been made towards general and complete disarmament and noted particularly the agreement in the United Nations General Assembly this year on a draft treaty on the non-proliferation of nuclear weapons. The Ministers agreed that effective action to prevent the proliferation of nuclear weapons would be an important step forward. The Ministers considered the special problems which would be presented if all nuclear powers did not participate in the treaty for the banning of nuclear tests, and if they did not become parties to the treaty on the non-proliferation of nuclear weapons.

§10. In an exchange of views on the problems of the maintenance of peace, the Ministers reaffirmed their support for the purposes and principles of the United Nations Charter. They recognised the value of regional arrangements for peace and security such as those envisaged in Article 52 of the Charter and also recognised the present existence of various arrangements of this kind.

§11. The Ministers expressed pleasure that ASPAC countries have continued to make substantial progress in agricultural and industrial development and in the expansion of their trade. They noted, however, that these gains had been made against a background of falling prices for many primary commodities, of a slowing down in the rate of growth of the trade of most of the economically more advanced countries, and of strains on international reserve currencies. They expressed

the hope that these adverse factors would not persist and that measures taken by the international community to provide opportunity for developing countries and to assist their economic and social advancement would be sustained.

§12. The Ministers reiterated their previously expressed view that ASPAC was not an exclusive group but an outward-looking organisation which was seeking to promote mutual understanding through frank exchanges of views, more than being concerned with reaching formal conclusions. ASPAC was not intended to be a body directed against any state or group of states. Its activities should be directed towards encouraging consultations and strengthening co-operation among the countries in the region. The Ministers welcomed the existence in the region of a number of organisations pursuing broadly similar aims. The fact that the organisations shared a degree of overlapping membership would help bring about close and harmonious co-operation between them. In this connection the Ministers noted that the Standing Committee of ASPAC had formally welcomed the creation of ASEAN.

§13. Recognising the contribution which ASPAC has already made to strengthening the bonds of solidarity among nations of the region and to accelerating mutual co-operation in economic, social and cultural fields; endorsing the need to strengthen further the valuable and effective system for consultation and co-operation existing among them; and, in the light of the Communiqués issued after their First and Second Meetings, the Ministers affirmed the determination of ASPAC countries to uphold the following principles and objectives:

(i) Mutual respect for national sovereignty, political independence and territorial integrity;

(ii) Attainment of equality, freedom and justice for all;

(iii) Pursuit of peace and settlement of disputes by peaceful means and respect for the rule of law;

(iv) Realism of a regional community where peace, order and progress are ensured;

(v) Emphasis upon self-reliance of the Asian and Pacific peoples based on their sense of a common destiny and regional solidarity;

(vi) Promotion of close co-operation in economic, social and cultural fields in order to further the development of a prosperous community of Asian and Pacific nations;

(vii) Strengthening of collaboration with other nations and existing international and regional organisations.

§14. The Ministers noted the report of the Standing Committee and expressed their gratification at the progress of the organisation as

recorded in the Report, and their appreciation of the work of the Chairman and members of the Committee.

§15. Recalling their decision in Bangkok that consultations between ASPAC members in international organisations should be further extended, the Ministers noted that in the last year the Standing Committee had arranged for informal consultations to take place between representatives of ASPAC delegations at more than twenty international conferences. The Ministers considered that these consultations had enhanced the value of their countries membership in ASPAC and their participation in the conferences in question. They considered that, as the practice of consultations in international organisations grew, the consultations would become increasingly valuable. They therefore decided that they should be continued and, where appropriate, extended in 1968-69.

§16. The Ministers formally approved the Draft Agreement submitted by the Standing Committee for an ASPAC Cultural and Social Centre to be set up in Seoul and agreed that the Agreement should be open for signature at the conclusion of their meeting. They noted that the costs of establishment and administration of the Centre would be met by the Government of the Republic of Korea and that the cost of operations of the Centre would be shared by participating governments. They also noted that Governments which are neither members nor observers of the Council were eligible for membership of the Centre.

§17. The Ministers expressed pleasure that the ASPAC Registry of Experts' Services, which had now been officially opened, had begun functioning. They noted that the Director of the Registry had visited member countries and that, on the basis of the cooperative working relationship being established between member governments and the Registry it should soon be able to make a real contribution to the development of the region.

§18. The Ministers commended the initiative of the Republic of China in proposing the establishment of a Food and Fertilizer Technology Centre for the Asian and Pacific region and recognised that such a Centre could help meet a real and pressing need in the region. The Ministers directed that the Standing Committee should, as a matter of urgency, give careful consideration to the scope, mode of operation, financing and administrative structure of such a Centre, with due regard to the avoidance of duplication with the work of other international bodies in the same field. The Ministers recorded their appreciation to the Republic of China for its invitation to convene a group of experts to assist the Standing Committee in its work. The Ministers requested that a detailed proposal for the establishment of the Centre be submitted

to them for their consideration at the Fourth Ministerial Meeting.

§19. The Ministers received with appreciation the proposal of the Government of Thailand for the establishment of an Economic Coordination Center for the Asian and Pacific region. They directed the Standing Committee to consider the proposal with due regard to the work of existing organisations in the region.

§20. The Ministers agreed that the Standing Committee should consider ways of appraising and processing existing and new proposals for consideration by the Council, including the proposal made by the Secretary of Foreign Affairs of the Philippines that the Standing Committee establish a non-permanent Study Group which would study the various economic or quasi-economic agencies and entities operating in the ASPAC region, their objectives, plans, programmes and projects with a view to determining precisely areas of activity in which ASPAC might engage; and the suggestion of the Government of the Republic of Korea that the Standing Committee arrange for studies of measures to expand and facilitate trade. In this connection attention was drawn to paragraph 9 of the Joint Communique of the Second Ministerial Meeting, Bangkok 5 - 7 July 1967 as follows:

“The Ministers noted the work being undertaken in other international organisations in such fields of regional economic integration and co-operation as the liberation of trade, the harmonisation and coordination of economic plans and payment arrangements, as well as the strengthening of economic infrastructures. The Ministers agreed that there would be merit in having the Standing Committee study such work on a continuing basis with a view to ascertaining what aspects are of relevance to ASPAC activities.”

§21. Ministers agreed that they should continue to meet annually. In response to an invitation from the Chairman, who was supported by other members of the Council, the Foreign Minister of Japan expressed the willingness of his Government to hold the Fourth Ministerial meeting of the Council in Japan in 1969. As a consequence of Japan's acceptance and in accordance with the established practice, the Standing Committee of ASPAC will meet in Tokyo under the chairmanship of the Minister for Foreign Affairs of Japan during the coming twelve months, and the Japanese Government will act as a clearing house and provide a working Secretariat pending and during the Fourth Ministerial meeting.

§22. Ministers expressed their warm appreciation for the cordial and generous hospitality of the Government and people of Australia for the meetings of the Standing Committee and the Council in Canberra.

THE NECESSITY OF A JUST PEACE

A TELEVISED ADDRESS

by

PRESIDENT NGUYEN VAN THIEU

August 23, 1968

(Excerpts)

We are longing for peace. But as I have stated many times, it should be a peace in honor and with justice. It will become a reality only when the Communist regime in North Viet-Nam realizes that its aggression, and the sacrifices it requires from the population under its control in North Viet-Nam in the pursuit of that aggression, are futile.

The Communists remain stubborn because they are still hoping that, by dragging out this war and by launching major offensives, they can break the will to resist among the allied nations. No expectations are more illusory, and such illusions will prove to be very costly to them.

The Communists must be aware that they can never win a military victory against the Allied Forces. The balance of power is too much to their disadvantage. On the other hand, the Communists have suffered very heavy losses since the beginning of the Lunar New Year.

However, as everyone knows, the Communists always subordinate their military activities to political aims. In an attempt to win the "battle of the headlines", as during their treacherous Tet attacks, and to foster defeatist movements among certain segments of public opinion in the allied countries, the Communists have been intensively preparing for another major offensive against various areas in the Republic of Viet-Nam.

Whereas, in an unilateral gesture of goodwill, we have stopped the bombings over most of the territory of North Viet-Nam, the Hanoi regime has not responded with any parallel restraint. On the contrary, they have taken full advantage of our partial cessation of bombing to increase very substantially their infiltration of troops and weapons into South Viet-Nam. In the past four months, the rate of infiltration of Communist troops from the North into the Republic of Viet-Nam is approximately 30,000 men a month, that is about four times the monthly rate of infiltration in previous months.

Through other indicators, such as enemy troop movements and concentrations, captured documents and enemy prisoners, we have known for some time now that the Communists are actively preparing another offensive.

Therefore the so-called lull in the past few months is not an indication of deescalation by the other side, it only reflects their preparations for another offensive, as well as the success of our spoiling operations against them.

In the past few days, the Communist aggressors have intensified their military activities and resumed their attacks in many parts of the country, especially in the western provinces of the Delta and in the Capital area. For political reasons, the capital city of Saigon seems to remain a major target for the enemy. Whether or not the enemy will effectively launch a large-scale offensive in the coming weeks depends on the extent to which they would be able to infiltrate additional troops and move them to targeted areas.

We stand ready for any eventuality.

We do hope however that the leaders of the Hanoi regime will soon come to reason, and will not create another futile blood bath.

In the past Communist offensives, the Armed Forces and civilian population of the Republic of Viet-Nam have shown in unmistakable manner how the next one will be met.

As for our Allies, they have also indicated in unequivocal terms their unwavering determination to resist and repel aggression. At the Summit Conference in Honolulu last July [1968], President Johnson solemnly stated that the pledge of the United States to help the Vietnamese people defeat aggression stands firm against all obstacles and against any deception.

A large majority of the American people, in a public opinion poll taken a few days ago, also take a strong position against the total unconditional cessation of bombing of North Viet-Nam, and against the formation of a so-called coalition government with the Communists in the Republic of Viet-Nam.

Other allied governments have conveyed to me the same assurances as the United States Government, and their peoples remain equally firm in the defense of freedom.

The Communist offensives during Tet and last May only turned international public opinion against them, and strengthened our determination to resist brutal force.

We do not want to expand this war, nor do we contemplate solving it by military means, except for those made necessary by our self-defense efforts. The Hanoi regime, for its part, must understand that it is utterly unrealistic for it to expect a military victory, or even a political victory based on brutal and treacherous attacks.

For the reestablishment of peace, the situation established by the Geneva Agreements of 1954 and 1962 has to be restored, pending the solution of Vietnamese political problems by and among the Vietnamese themselves.

In the Honolulu Joint Communiqué of last July [20, 1968], I have made clear the views of the Government of Viet-Nam on the essential conditions of peace, which reflect the basic dispositions of the 1954 Armistice Convention:

- The re-establishment of the 17th parallel as the demarcation line between North Viet-Nam and South Viet-Nam, pending the determination by the free choice of all Vietnamese on reunification;

- Respect for the territorial integrity of the Republic of Viet-Nam;

- Complete cessation of hostilities and subversion, and withdrawal from the territory of the Republic of Viet-Nam of all Communist military and subversive forces to the North;

- Full compliance with the principle of non-interference between North and South Viet-Nam;

- Effective international supervision and guarantees.

When peace and security are restored, there will be two major sets of problems which could be usefully discussed among the Vietnamese: the reunification of Viet-Nam, and the political questions that remain in the Republic of Viet-Nam.

On these two major sets of problems, I have also clearly stated the policy of the Government of Viet-Nam.

At the 1954 Geneva Conference, Free Viet-Nam opposed the partition of the country, which was advocated by the Viet-Minh, the present rulers of North Viet-Nam.

When peace is restored, the Government of Viet-Nam is ready to explore with the authorities in North Viet-Nam all the avenues which may lead to the reunification of the country by peaceful means, through the free and democratic choice of all Vietnamese in the North and in the South. Pending actual reunification, the gradual normalization of economic, cultural, and family relations between North Viet-Nam and South Viet-Nam can be usefully explored. This is an issue which can be decided only by a common accord between the Government of Viet-Nam and the authorities now in control of North Viet-Nam.

Another important problem relates to the political question remaining in the Republic of Viet-Nam. On this issue, I reaffirm the policy of the Government which is to seek an amicable, just and

peaceful solution. We seek no victory, no revenge over our misguided citizens, but only reconciliation with justice and under the law.

All of our citizens who are now on the other side, and fighting against us, have the choice between a criminal, destructive, and hazardous life, and a constructive life in peace and national brotherhood: as soon as they lay down their weapons, renounce violence, and abide by the law of the land, they will have the full rights of citizenship. They will enjoy exactly the same civil and political rights and assume the same responsibilities as the other citizens, and as such will be able to participate in our national life under the principle of one-man one-vote, in accordance with our national Constitution.

Rewards will be offered to those of the returnees who contribute to the shortening of this criminal war waged by the Communist aggressors, commensurate with the services rendered.

All the returnees, who come back to the national fold as peaceful and law abiding citizens, will find a deserving place commensurate with their talents and aptitudes.

They will also have the great moral satisfaction of really serving the best interests of the Fatherland.

Beyond Viet-Nam, we seek reconciliation and peace throughout Asia and the Pacific, in the spirit of the Honolulu Conference.

While hoping for peace with justice and honor, and the coming of an era of constructive cooperation in Southeast Asia, I cannot help but feeling concerned by the turn of events in Czechoslovakia in the past few days, and their portentous significance for the cause of freedom, and national independence everywhere.

We are fighting in Viet-Nam for the principle of non-interference in the internal affairs of sovereign states, for the right for every nation to live in peace, and to choose its own way of life, and its own path to the future, free from coercion and subjugation. We also deeply believe that the respect of these fundamental rights is indispensable to a durable peace in the world. We therefore deeply deplore the brutal repression of the budding aspirations of the Czechoslovak people for freedom, independence, and human dignity.

After the Hungarian events and the peasants' revolt in North Viet-Nam in 1956, the recent efforts toward liberalization and democratization in Czechoslovakia show the deep aspirations for freedom among men everywhere. They also show that freedom is always ruthlessly repressed in a Communist society, because even timid expressions of freedom already represent a serious threat to Communist tyranny, a threat not only implied in the very nature of freedom, but also a threat

because of the effects they have as an example to others.

Another lesson to be drawn from the Hungarian and Czechoslovak events is that national independence in the Communist world is only a myth, especially when a small Communist country lives next to a big Communist neighbor.

These events reveal the emptiness and tragic irony of the Communist claim that they fight for the 'liberation' of the Republic of Viet-Nam as they attempt to impose on us a regime obedient to international Communism, all the while pretending to be the standard-bearers of Vietnamese national independence.

The Communist regime in North Viet-Nam has been trying to impose by force a political regime on the people of the Republic of Viet-Nam in invoking the pretext of helping the local Communists and pretending to have a right to do so, in the same fashion that Soviet Russia invaded Czechoslovakia under the pretense of aiding the Czechoslovak Communists. The Communist North Vietnamese do not realize that, should they succeed in their criminal attempts against the freedom of the Republic of Viet-Nam, they themselves would become an easy prey for their big Communist neighbor.

A free society therefore is not only the necessary framework for the progress and the happiness of the Vietnamese people, it constitutes also the best guarantee for the national independence of Viet-Nam, as it assures us the support of other free countries in the defense of our Free World.

Therefore our misguided citizens who have been deluded by Communist propaganda should ponder about the Government's policy on national reconciliation, and the recent events in the Communist world, to find the right path to the truth and to the salvation of the country.

THE OBJECTIVES OF PEACE

A LETTER TO U THANT

sent by

FOREIGN MINISTER TRAN CHANH THANH

September 4, 1968

Excellency,

On the eve of the Twenty-third General Assembly of the United Nations, I wish to convey to Your Excellency my greetings and appreciation for your repeated efforts to bring about an early end to the conflict in Viet-Nam and for your unending and dedicated search for peace in Asia and in the world.

Few people have experienced greater human suffering and material loss than the Vietnamese. And no other people certainly desire more peace and security than the 16 million residents of South Viet-Nam, so that we may heal the wounds of war and rebuild our country which has been devastated by a brutal aggression carefully prepared and imposed on us and which in fact had not ceased at any time since 1954.

The ink was hardly dry on the Geneva Agreements which they themselves signed in 1954 when the North Vietnamese leaders began to violate them systematically. Despite the main provisions of these Agreements which provided that forces on both sides be regrouped into one or the other side of the demarcation line drawn at the 17th parallel, the Hanoi authorities left in the South many trained political and subversive cadres as well as numerous caches of weapons and ammunition, for the obvious purpose of using them at the right time.

Then began a period of intense propaganda along with acts of terrorism so as to undermine the authority of the legal Government and intimidate the people. North Vietnamese politico-military cadres, weapons and ammunition were infiltrated at an increasing rate into the South.

With such reinforcements and supplies from the North, the Communists were in a position to add guerilla warfare to their propaganda and sabotage activities.

On September 5, 1960, a Congress of the North Vietnamese Communist Party—the Lao Dong Party—gave itself the task of “liberating” South Viet-Nam. Three months later, Hanoi announced the creation

of the "National Liberation Front of South Viet-Nam" entrusted with this mission. Thus there is an obvious correlation between the above-mentioned propaganda, acts of war and the creation of this Front.

The Legal Committee of the International Control Commission recognized the truth of these facts in its report dated June 2, 1962:

"... there is evidence to show that armed and unarmed personnel, arms, munitions and other supplies have been sent from the Zone in the North to the Zone in the South with the object of supporting, organizing and carrying out hostile activities, including armed attacks directed against the Armed Forces and Administration of the Zone in the South.

"These acts are in violation of articles 10, 19, 24, and 27 of the Agreements on the cessation of hostilities in Vietnam. . ."

Throughout these last 14 years, the people and Government of the Republic of Viet-Nam are therefore the daily victims of an immense campaign of subversion and aggression fomented, directed and ceaselessly supported by the Hanoi regime, with the assistance of countries of the Communist bloc. It consists of acts of indiscriminate terrorism often directed against the innocent population, systematic sabotage of the economic stability and social realization throughout the country, incessant infiltration of regular troops as well as trained cadres, open introduction of the most modern and sophisticated weapons of the Communist war arsenal, including heavy mortars, rockets, recoilless cannons. . .

The will of the Hanoi authorities to impose communism by force over South Viet-Nam has been affirmed more and more clearly and the clandestine subversion at the beginning is now an open war against the people and Government of the Republic of Viet-Nam, a situation which very seriously threatens the peace in this area of the world.

Faced with this well-prepared and massive aggression started by North Viet-Nam and assisted by the Communist bloc—the Chief of the North Vietnamese delegation in Paris, Xuan Thuy, recently claimed it actually started in 1959—the Republic of Viet-Nam has no other choice than to take up arms to defend herself. After having borne alone the brunt of the struggle for a long time, she finally requested the assistance of her Allies in 1962 to help defend her freedom, in legitimate right of self-defence. A call to world aid was reiterated in 1964. Forty-three countries responded to that call with their technical, economic, medical and humanitarian assistance so as to help rebuild the country, relieve the burden of sufferings of the people, improve their standard of living.

The aggressive policy of the Communists is given a new illustration in Czechoslovakia. The tragic events in Czechoslovakia and in Viet-Nam show that Communist countries act in a similar manner to stifle any aspirations of the people to independence and freedom. The precipitate approval of North Viet-Nam which hailed the invasion of Czechoslovakia as an operation to fulfill "a noble goal" is proof of its close dependence on the Soviet Union which has repeatedly and publicly stated that it was supplying North Viet-Nam with the major part of the war material being used against the Republic of Viet-Nam, therefore making possible the prolongation of the war and the daily holocaust in our country.

The Republic of Viet-Nam has the right to resist aggression to fight back violence, to repulse intervention by force into her national life. She only wants to save her independence and freedom, to defend her right to life and peace. Such is her only unique objective.

As far as she is concerned, the Republic of Viet-Nam wants to live in peace and has never nurtured nor is entertaining any hostile plan against North Viet-Nam or her neighbors.

In this spirit, the Republic of Viet-Nam has repeatedly appealed to the leaders of the Hanoi regime for direct discussions in view of a peaceful solution and an end to the innumerable sufferings of the people.

To emphasize our readiness for direct negotiations, we have agreed to a curtailment of the aerial bombardment of North Viet-Nam, although this actually represented an open opportunity for North Viet-Nam to accelerate the movement of its armed forces and war equipment toward the South.

The Communist regime in Hanoi has responded to this manifestation of goodwill by launching a second wave of attacks against Saigon and other cities in South Viet-Nam in May this year, by repeatedly and indiscriminately bombarding the civilian population of the Capital and other populated areas.

Under these circumstances, an unconditional and total cessation of the bombardment as claimed by North Viet-Nam, if it is not preceded by a clear-cut and positive manifestation of reciprocal restraint on their part, would only result in increased infiltration of troops and war material into South Viet-Nam and lead to further bloodshed and more casualties for both sides.

In the Honolulu Joint Communique of last July 20, 1968, the Republic of Viet-Nam has made clear its views regarding the essential conditions of peace, which reflect the basic dispositions of the 1954 Geneva Armistice Agreement and are in accord with the 1962 Agreement on Laos:

— The re-establishment of the 17th parallel as the demarcation line between North Viet-Nam and South Viet-Nam, pending the determination by the free choice of all Vietnamese on reunification;

— Respect for the territorial integrity of the Republic of Viet-Nam;

— Complete cessation of hostilities and subversion, and withdrawal from the territory of the Republic of Viet-Nam of all Communist military and subversive forces to the North;

— Full compliance with the principle of non-interference between North and South Viet-Nam;

— Effective international supervision and guarantees.

Concerning the presence of Allied forces in the South, the Government and people of South Viet-Nam have requested their support to resist aggression. However, as North Viet-Nam withdraws its forces to the North, ceases infiltration, and the level of violence thus subsides, the Republic of Viet-Nam will ask her Allies to remove their forces and evacuate their military installations, in accordance with the Manila Communique of October 26, 1966.

When peace is restored, the Republic of Viet-Nam is ready to discuss with the authorities in North Viet-Nam all the avenues which may lead to the reunification of the country by peaceful means, through the free and democratic choice of all Vietnamese in the North and in the South. Pending actual reunification, the gradual normalization of economic, cultural and family relations between North Viet-Nam and South Viet-Nam can be usefully explored by common accord between the Republic of Viet-Nam and the authorities in North Viet-Nam.

The objectives of the Republic of Viet-Nam are simple and reasonable indeed. They proceed from our deep aspirations for peace and human compassion and our respect for international law and order.

In their struggle for survival and their quest for peace, the people of South Viet-Nam have exerted their right to self-determination through general elections in 1966 and 1967 to select their Constitution, their Government and representatives at the Senate and House of Representatives, as well as local councils at the hamlet and provincial levels.

They reject solution proposals such as a "coalition government" of which Viet-Nam has had a bitter experience in 1946, or any overt or disguised territorial concession. Neither solution would bring back peace, it would simply lead to an inevitable communist takeover or a

larger war after a short period of disorder.

The people and Government of the Republic of Viet-Nam seek a genuine, just and lasting peace. It must not be a deceptive peace, and must be impervious to renewed hostilities. Such a peace would be on the basis of peaceful co-existence, non-aggression and non-interference in the internal affairs of both North and South.

For its part, the Republic of Viet-Nam rejects the principles of retaliation and revenge, in favor of national reconciliation, and is offering full participation to all individuals and members of groups who accept to renounce force and abide by the Constitution and laws of Viet-Nam.

We still hold that if North Viet-Nam leaders were genuinely interested in peace discussions, they should respond to our appeal for direct negotiations between South and North Viet-Nam, as the most logical and practical means to put an end to the bloody tragedy which has lasted all too long.

Please accept, Excellency, the renewed assurances of my highest consideration.

Saigon, September 4, 1968

SIGNED: TRAN CHANH THANH

Minister of Foreign Affairs

Republic of Viet-Nam

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1. INAUGURAL ADDRESS by President Nguyen Van Thieu, October 31, 1967.
2. PERSPECTIVE ON PEACE IN VIET-NAM by President Nguyen Van Thieu, January 15, 1968.
3. ON PEACE AND MANPOWER REQUIREMENTS by President Nguyen Van Thieu, April 10, 1968.
4. PEACE AND BEYOND, Official Statements and Communiqués on Peace and Postwar Development, July-September 1968.

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